MOST IMPROVED COLLEGE*
Department of Architecture, NIT Hamirpur
Hamirpur

Scaling All New Highs

The fragile Himalayan ecosystem serves as a living laboratory for architecture students here, exposing students to unique challenges

By **SAROJ KUMAR**

The Department of Architecture at National Institute of Technology (NIT) Hamirpur in Himachal Pradesh has emerged as a leading centre for the study of the discipline, with a distinct focus on the local, be it hill region development, climate-responsive design or sustainable builds. Established in 2000, it is one of the youngest academic departments at NIT Hamirpur, but has rapidly built a reputation for excellence—moving up from No. 11 in the rankings in 2022 to No. 6 in 2026. Today, it caters to 380 students across undergraduate, postgraduate and doctoral programmes. The academic philosophy encourages students to view architecture not merely as the building of structures but as a response to the needs of communities and the environment.

What distinguishes the department from other architecture schools is its location. The fragile Himalayan ecosystem serves as a living laboratory for students, exposing them to the unique challenges of designing for the terrain. From landslides and extreme weather events to rapid urbanisation in hill towns, students learn to address real-world issues through field visits, case studies and live projects. This emphasis on site-specific and climate-responsive architecture has become increasingly relevant as governments and planners seek solutions for ecologically sensitive regions.

Dr Ashwani Kumar, associate professor and head of the Department of Architecture,



BArch students outside the department building

ARUN KUMAR